

READING DOSSIER

Of Md. Miraz Hossain

Five Foundational Texts and What They Assume

MSJ2251: Journalism and Society

Spring 2024

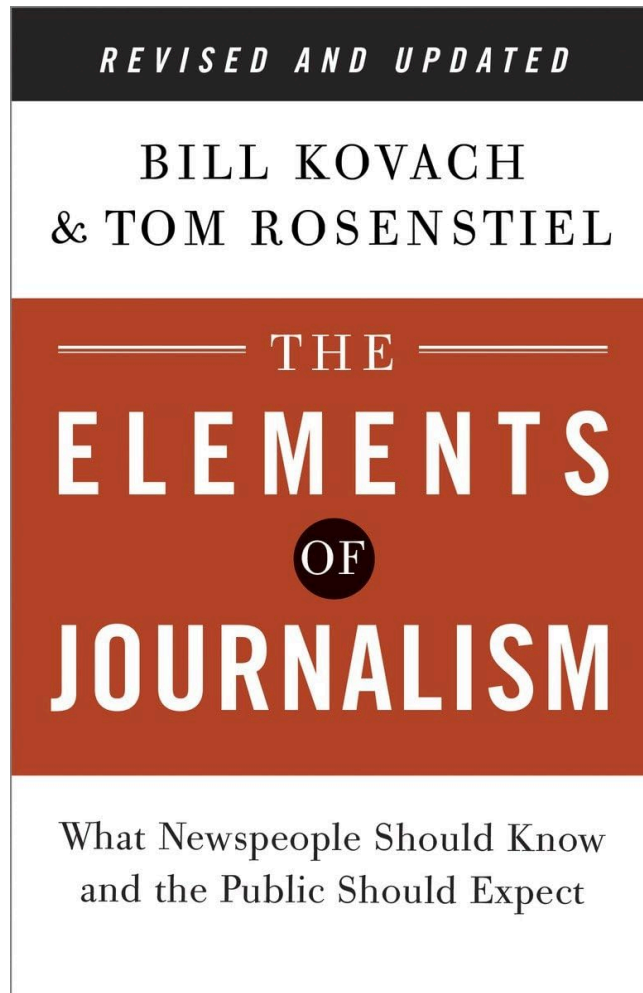
Introduction

What is journalism for? The question sounds foundational but it is answered differently depending on who is asking and where. Press freedom advocacy takes one answer for granted: journalism exists to inform citizens, hold power accountable, and sustain democratic deliberation. That answer is defensible. It is also historically specific, culturally particular, and regularly contradicted by what journalism actually does in practice — including in contexts where the democratic framework it presupposes is fragile, contested, or under direct attack.

The five texts in this dossier constitute the foundational literature of journalism studies as a scholarly field. They do not agree with each other. Kovach and Rosenstiel's normative account of journalism's obligations sits in tension with Hallin and Mancini's structural account of how media systems actually work. Schudson's sociology of newsroom practice complicates the idea that journalists straightforwardly apply professional standards to produce reliable knowledge. Zelizer challenges journalism studies to take seriously what journalists actually know and how they know it. Christians et al. try to hold multiple normative frameworks simultaneously without collapsing them into a single model.

Each text is annotated here under three questions: what the argument actually is, where its assumptions become analytically problematic, and what it illuminates — or fails to illuminate — when applied to the Bangladeshi context. The last question is not a demand that Western scholarship speak directly to non-Western cases. It is a methodological tool: cases where frameworks break down or require heavy qualification reveal assumptions that the frameworks themselves do not make visible.

**Text 1: Kovach & Rosenstiel, The Elements of Journalism
(2001/2014)**



The Argument

Kovach and Rosenstiel's book is the most widely read normative account of what journalism is and what it is obligated to do. Drawing on a large-scale survey of practitioners and educators, they identify nine core elements: obligation to truth, loyalty to citizens, verification discipline, independence from those covered, independent monitoring of power, provision of a forum for criticism and compromise, effort to make the significant interesting, proportionate coverage, and journalists' personal obligation of conscience. These elements constitute, in their account, journalism's social covenant with the public and distinguish it from other forms of communication.

The loyalty-to-citizens formulation is the framework's most analytically useful contribution. It distinguishes between primary accountability — to the public — and the competing claims of sources, employers, advertisers, and political actors. That distinction is practically significant and frequently violated in practice, which is precisely why having a vocabulary for it matters. The emphasis on verification discipline as the core professional practice is also substantive: it specifies what journalistic knowledge claims are supposed to rest on and how they are supposed to be defended.

Where the Assumptions Break

The framework's normative validity — its claims about what journalism should do — is separable from its analytical usefulness for understanding what journalism actually does in constrained environments. On the normative side, the elements are coherent and well argued. On the analytical side, the framework presupposes institutional conditions that are not universally present: a media environment in which legal risks attach primarily to falsehood and fabrication rather than to accurate reporting; economic conditions that allow professional journalists to maintain independence from advertisers and political actors; and a political environment in which accountability journalism generates reputational costs for officials rather than legal or physical costs for journalists.

When those conditions are absent, the framework does not simply become harder to apply — it misidentifies where the problem lies. A journalist who cannot practice the verification discipline Kovach and Rosenstiel describe because sources will not speak on record for fear of state retaliation is not failing to uphold professional standards. The standard itself cannot be operated under those conditions. The framework has no account of this because it was not built to have one: it was designed to articulate what journalism should aspire to, not to explain the structural conditions under which aspiration becomes impossible.

Bangladesh Annotation

The Digital Security Act, before its amendment, created conditions under which verification discipline became professionally dangerous. Journalists who reported verified facts about government misconduct faced prosecution under provisions broad enough to criminalise accurate reporting. The framework's assumption that practicing its elements is professionally protective did not hold. This is not an argument against the elements as normative ideals. It is an argument that the framework needs a structural supplement — an account of the institutional conditions under which its prescriptions can be enacted.

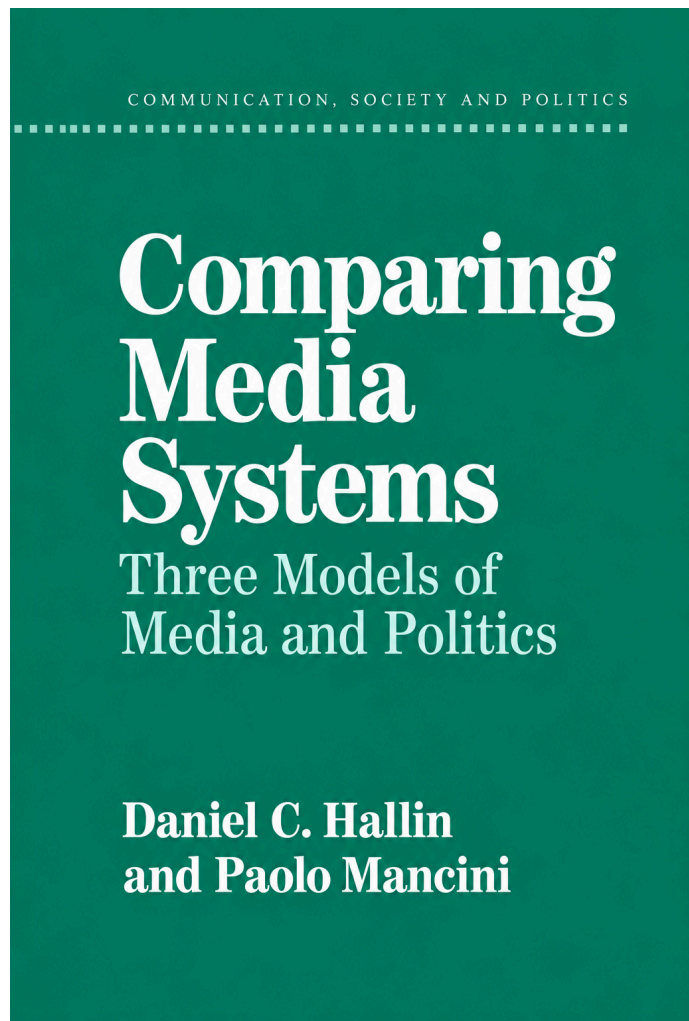
Text 2: Hallin & Mancini, Comparing Media Systems (2004)

The Argument

Hallin and Mancini's comparative study identifies three models of media system organisation in Western Europe and North America, defined by four variables: media market development, political parallelism (the alignment of media outlets with political parties or tendencies), journalistic professionalisation, and state intervention. The Mediterranean or Polarised Pluralist model (southern Europe) combines high political parallelism with weak commercial development and significant state involvement. The Northern European or Democratic Corporatist model (Scandinavia and central Europe) combines strong commercial press,

strong public broadcasting, and robust professional norms. The North Atlantic or Liberal model (UK, USA, Canada, Ireland) is dominated by commercial media with relatively limited state intervention and institutionally strong professional journalism.

The methodological contribution is more durable than any of the three models. The insistence that media systems cannot be understood independently of the broader political and social structures they operate within is correct and necessary. Journalism looks different in different institutional environments not because of random variation



but because of structured differences in ownership, political economy, legal frameworks, and professional culture. Any analysis that treats media content without accounting for those structural conditions is likely to mistake contingent institutional outcomes for natural or universal ones.

Where the Assumptions Break

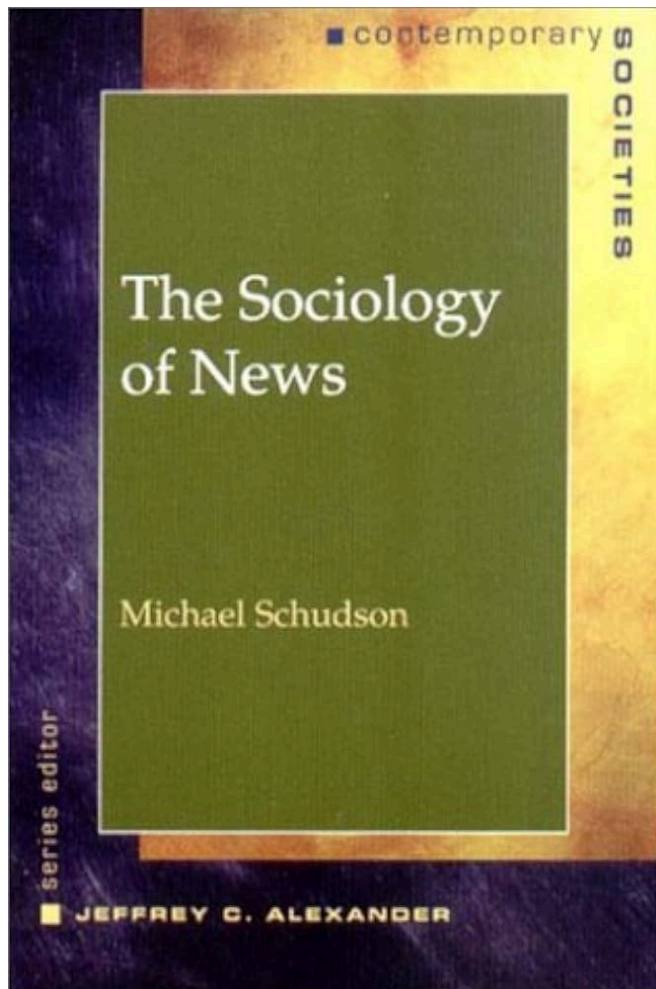
Hallin and Mancini acknowledged in their 2012 follow-up that their framework was built on Western cases and required modification for other regions. The acknowledgment understated the problem. The three models were developed in contexts with competitive multiparty democratic systems, relatively stable state institutions, and media markets that had developed over decades without significant interruption. The professionalisation axis — measuring how developed professional journalism norms and practices are — treats professionalisation as a continuous variable, as though Bangladesh and Norway simply occupy different points on the same scale.

This is conceptually misleading. In contexts where professional norms are systematically undermined by legal, economic, or political pressure, the question is not how far along a professionalisation trajectory a media system is. The question is whether the institutional conditions for professional journalism as a practice can exist at all under those constraints. A media system operating under direct legal threat to accurate reporting is not simply less professionalised than Sweden. It is operating under a different structural logic that the Hallin-Mancini framework was not designed to capture.

Bangladesh Annotation

The Bangladeshi media system shows features of the Polarised Pluralist model — significant political parallelism, state intervention through licensing and advertising, weak institutional press freedom protections — alongside features the model does not capture: a donor-funded civil society media sector with distinct accountability structures; a diaspora press operating under Swedish press freedom law (Netra News is the clearest example); and a social media environment that has, in specific political moments, functioned as a partial substitute for institutional journalism. The Hallin-Mancini variables remain useful for comparative analysis. The models require substantial contextualisation before they can describe what those variables produce here.

Text 3: Schudson, The Sociology of News (2003)



The Argument

Schudson asks, sociologically, how news comes to look the way it does. His multi-factor framework identifies several determinants of news content: political economy (ownership, market pressures), social organisation (beats, routines, source relationships), cultural factors (narrative conventions, professional values), and technology (the affordances and constraints of different media forms). No single factor is determinative; news is produced at the intersection of all of them. The central conceptual move, drawing on Tuchman's (1972) earlier work, is the "strategic ritual of objectivity": the use of procedural norms — attribution to named sources, seeking comment from

multiple parties, separating fact from opinion — as institutional protection against accusations of bias. Objectivity, on this account, is not a description of what journalists achieve. It is a professional practice that defends against criticism by demonstrating procedure.

Where the Assumptions Break

The sociology of news tradition was developed through studies of American and British newsrooms. The organisational routines it describes are features of a specific model of institutional journalism: relatively well-resourced, operating within stable

professional communities, with source access secured through established beat relationships. These conditions do not obtain universally, and in their absence, the relative autonomy of professional practice that Schudson describes is constrained in ways his framework does not fully theorise.

The strategic ritual of objectivity raises a more pointed question in constrained media environments. The ritual — seeking official comment, attributing claims, maintaining the form of balanced coverage — can be performed in contexts where the substantive conditions for independent reporting are absent. A journalist working under legal or economic pressure may practice all the procedural elements of objectivity while producing coverage that systematically avoids holding specific actors accountable. The ritual is intact. The function it is supposed to serve is not. Schudson identifies this gap briefly but does not develop it. It is one of the most important dynamics in journalism under political constraint, and it deserves more analytical attention than the framework gives it.

Bangladesh Annotation

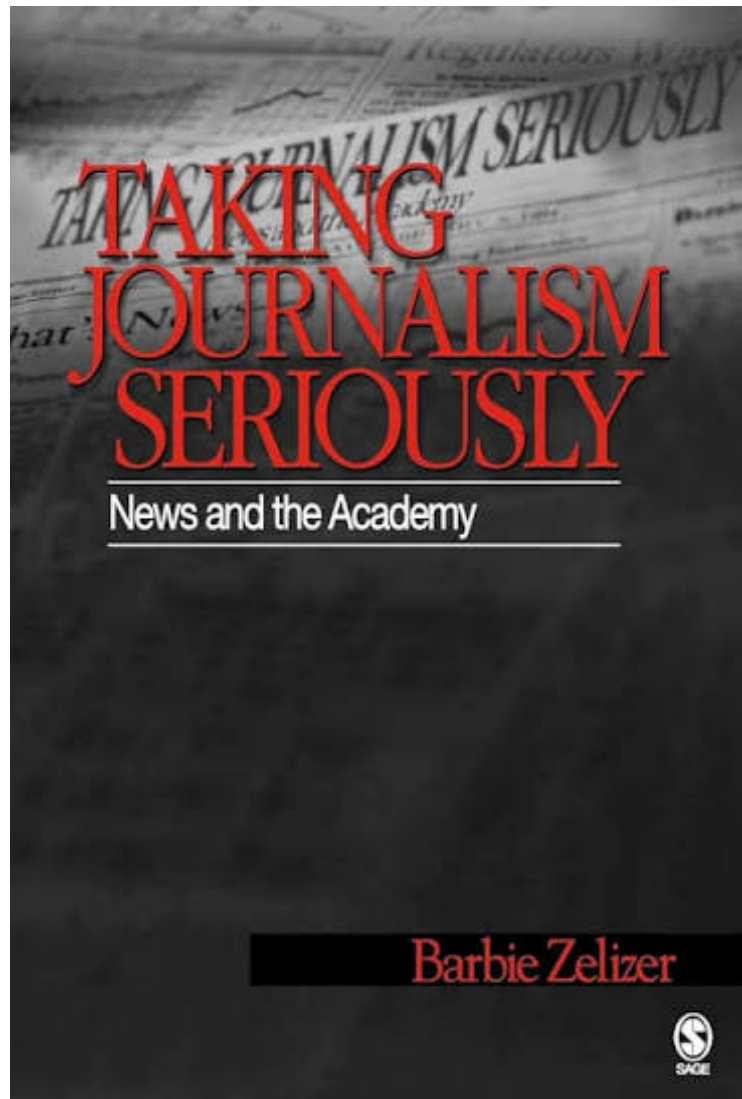
The strategic ritual of objectivity is directly observable in Bangladeshi political journalism. The formal procedures — seeking government comment, attributing claims to named officials, presenting both sides of contested matters — are widely practised. The substantive independence to report what those procedures, if genuine, would produce is unevenly distributed and structurally constrained. The ritual persists partly because it provides professional cover and partly because the norm of procedural objectivity is genuinely internalised. The gap between procedural form and substantive function is where the most interesting questions about Bangladeshi journalism lie.

Text 4: Zelizer, Taking Journalism Seriously (2004)

The Argument

Zelizer's intervention is meta-critical. She surveys journalism studies and argues that its disciplinary fragmentation has prevented the field from developing an account of journalism adequate to what journalism actually is. Political scientists studying journalism see political actors and institutional structures. Sociologists see organisations and routines. Cultural studies scholars see texts and representations. Each approach captures something real and misses something important. Her proposed alternative is to treat journalism as an interpretive community: a group of practitioners who share conventions of storytelling, standards of evidence, and practices of authentication that constitute a distinct knowledge culture. Understanding journalism requires taking seriously what journalists know, how they know it, and how those knowledge claims are validated within the community.

The interpretive community framework does useful work. It explains why professional consensus forms around certain stories and narrative structures — not



because they are the only or obviously correct way to tell a story, but because they are the conventions the community has developed and recognises as authoritative. It also explains why journalism is resistant to external critique in specific ways: challenges from outside the community are evaluated against community standards that the challenger may not share or accept.

Where the Assumptions Break

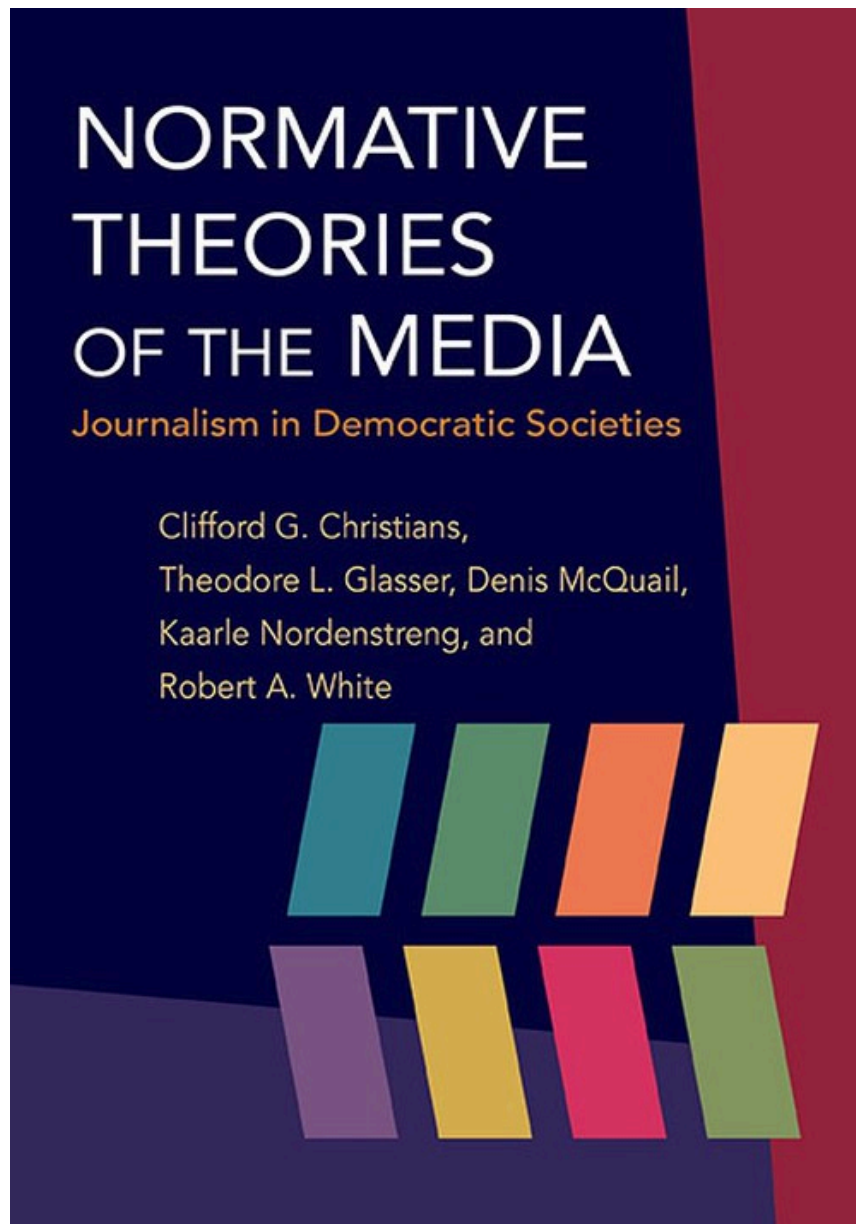
The framework is most analytically tractable when applied to consolidated professional communities — contexts where shared conventions are stable, institutionally reproduced, and relatively uncontested within the community. The question it does not adequately address is: what happens when the boundaries of the community are themselves contested? Who counts as a journalist, and by whose authority that determination is made, is not a purely professional question. It is a political one. Legal definitions, platform policies, accreditation systems, and public credibility all participate in drawing the boundary, and they do not always agree.

The authority of the interpretive community also depends on its social recognition. In contexts where professional journalism's credibility has been systematically eroded — through political capture, through demonstrated failures of coverage, through the availability of alternative information sources — the community's conventions and authentication rituals do not automatically transfer their authority to the news products they validate. Zelizer's framework assumes a relatively stable relationship between community membership, professional practice, and public credibility. That relationship is empirically variable in ways the framework needs to account for.

Bangladesh Annotation

In Bangladesh, the boundaries of the journalistic interpretive community are genuinely and consequentially contested. Trained journalists at established outlets, citizen reporters on social media, activists producing investigative content through civil society organisations, and diaspora journalists working from Sweden or elsewhere all produce content that circulates as journalism. The conventions and authentication rituals they employ are not the same. Whether they constitute a single community, multiple communities with different authority claims, or something more fragmented is not just a sociological question. It determines whose version of events gets treated as credible and whose gets treated as advocacy.

**Text 5: Christians, Glasser, McQuail, Nordenstreng & White,
Normative Theories of the Media (2009)**



The Argument

Christians et al. take normative media theory seriously as a scholarly programme rather than treating it as either prescriptive ideology or naive idealism. They identify four normative roles for media in democratic societies: the monitorial role (surveillance, information gathering, holding power accountable); the facilitative role (providing forums for civic deliberation and public discourse); the radical role (challenging established power and giving voice to

marginalised groups); and the collaborative role (supporting social cohesion, governance, and shared institutional frameworks). The framework is deliberately pluralist. It does not privilege the monitorial role — the fourth estate model that dominates liberal democratic press theory — over the others but argues that a functioning media system requires capacity across all four. Different media institutions may perform different roles; the system as a whole is evaluated across the full spectrum.

Where the Assumptions Break

The framework's pluralism is its analytical strength and its normative limitation. By treating all four roles as legitimate, it avoids the liberal bias of frameworks that recognise only accountability journalism as genuine journalism. But it provides limited guidance for cases of genuine conflict between roles, which are not exceptional but routine. When the monitorial role — exposing government corruption — conflicts with the collaborative role — maintaining social stability in a fragile political transition — which takes precedence? The framework identifies the tension. It does not resolve it.

This is not a trivial gap. In contexts of genuine political transition, the tension between monitoring and collaboration is the central editorial dilemma facing journalists, not a theoretical edge case. A decision to hold back a corruption story because its publication might destabilise a transitional process that has not yet secured democratic gains is simultaneously a failure of the monitorial role and a possible exercise of the collaborative role. Whether it is the right decision cannot be determined by consulting the four-role framework. What the framework offers is a vocabulary for describing the dilemma clearly — and that vocabulary is more useful than it might appear, because clarity about what is being traded off is the precondition for making a defensible editorial judgement.

Bangladesh Annotation

Post-July 2024, Bangladeshi journalists face the monitorial-collaborative tension in concrete form. The monitorial role demands coverage of interim government conduct with the same scrutiny applied to the Awami League government it replaced. The collaborative role, as some editors frame it, demands restraint in coverage that might destabilise a transition that has not yet secured its gains. Neither position is obviously wrong. The Christians et al. framework names what is at stake in that editorial choice more precisely than any of the other frameworks in this dossier — even if it cannot resolve it.

All in all: What the Canon Assumes

The five texts share a geographic and historical limitation. They were built on the North Atlantic liberal model and its European variants — at a specific moment in the development of those systems. The normative assumptions embedded in them, the empirical generalisations they derive, and the theoretical concepts they develop reflect conditions that were never universal and are now contested even where they originated.

The normative stakes of journalism's social function, the structural determinants of media system variation, the organisational production of news as a cultural artefact, and the knowledge claims journalism makes and how it validates them within a professional community. These are genuine contributions. The field would not have the vocabulary to ask its current questions without them.

What they obscure: the conditions under which journalism operates under systematic legal and economic constraint; the role of non-institutional actors — citizen journalists, diaspora media, civil society investigators — in producing accountability content; the relationship between domestic and transnational information environments; and the epistemic challenges specific to contexts where official sources are structurally unreliable and independent verification is structurally costly.

The productive move is not to dismiss the canon as Eurocentric and replace it with something else. It is to use cases where the frameworks strain or break — where the assumptions need to be made explicit before the framework can even be applied — to identify what those assumptions are. Kovach and Rosenstiel assume institutional conditions under which practicing their elements is professionally viable. Hallin and Mancini assume that professionalisation is a continuous developmental variable rather than a structurally conditioned possibility. Zelizer assumes a relatively stable relationship between professional community, shared convention, and public credibility. Making those assumptions visible, through the kind of friction this dossier tries to generate, is how non-Western journalism scholarship can contribute to the field rather than simply applying received frameworks to different empirical material.

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